

Escaping and embracing 'social grids' through TikTok

Why TikTok?

- Short video app; available since 2017; around 800 million active users
- Negative and patronising reporting on the app; image of it being an ultimate 'time-wasting machine' (e.g. Odell 2019)
- Case to understand discourses of the 'good life' in relation to digital media use

Remediation and Polymedia

- Focus on what prior forms of mediation new media build on (Bolter and Grusin 1998)
- Focus on practices of navigating environments of communicative affordances (Madianou and Miller 2012)
- Digital ethnography and series of interviews with 30 young adults based in UK

Escaping 'social grids'

- Sense of anxiety in relation to pandemic and lockdown life amplified on social media
- Sense of pressure to stay engaged on the 'social grid' because of technical possibility
- Sense of boredom both due to lockdown yet also on social media and spaces of mediated sociality
- Remediation of 'creating distance': going for a walk, watching tv series (Ang 1985), reading magazine (Hermes 1995), ...

Embracing 'social grids'

- Often unacknowledged social dimension of TikTok: sharing video clips with friends
- Keeping relations alive through meta communicative messages like 'thinking about you'
- Watching selection of TikToks together with close social ties, like partners, in physical co-presence

Getting off TikTok

- TikTok is a contradictory space, at once site of escape and site of connection. What does it mean to be 'on' or 'off'?
- Understanding environments like TikTok as the product of situated human-machine interaction (Suchman 2007)
- Shifting focus to rhythms and how 'digital architectures of enjoyment' are negotiated (Lefebvre 2014)

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